Handout: David Lewis – *Finkish Dispositions*

I. The Problem: Why the Simple Conditional Analysis Fails

At the heart of Lewis's paper is a familiar and intuitive thesis about dispositions:

- **Simple Conditional Analysis (SCA):**
  x is disposed to give response r to stimulus s iff if x were subjected to s, it would give r (p. 143).

This analysis treats dispositions as reducible to **counterfactual conditionals**.

Why this seems attractive:

- It aligns with ordinary language:
  - Fragility → would break if struck
  - Solubility → would dissolve if placed in water
- It promises a **reductive analysis** of dispositional properties in terms of modal/causal facts.

The Core Problem (Martin's Refutation): Finkish Dispositions

Lewis adopts C.B. Martin's critique: **the SCA is false**.

Finkish Disposition (Definition):

A disposition that **would disappear if tested**, thereby preventing its own manifestation.

- Example (p. 144–145):
  - A glass is fragile.
  - But if struck, it would *immediately lose* its fragility.
  - Therefore:
    - **Analysandum (disposition claim): TRUE**
    - **Analysans (counterfactual): FALSE**

II. Background: Dispositions, Analysandum, and Analysans

What is a Disposition?

A **dispositional property** is a property characterized by:

- A **stimulus condition (s)**
- A **manifestation (r)**

Examples:

- Fragility → breaks when struck
- Irritability → becomes angry when provoked

Dispositions are:

- Typically **modal** (concern what *would* happen)
- Often linked to **causal powers**

Analysandum vs Analysans

This distinction is central to Lewis's method:

- **Analysandum** = the concept being analyzed
  - Here: *"x is disposed to give r in response to s"*
- **Analysans** = the proposed analysis
  - Here: *"if x were subjected to s, it would give r"*

Lewis's strategy:

- Show that **analysandum can be true while analysans is false** → refutation.

III. Varieties of Finkishness

Lewis expands Martin's insight by showing multiple ways the SCA fails.

1. Finkish Possession of a Disposition (p. 144)

- x has disposition D
- If stimulus occurs → D disappears → no manifestation

Counterexample to SCA.

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2. Finkish Absence of a Disposition (p. 144)

- x lacks disposition D
- If stimulus occurs → x *gains* D → manifestation occurs

Now:

- **Analysans true**
- **Analysandum false**

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3. Paired Dispositions (p. 144–145)

- Dispositions may depend on **interactions between systems**
- One component's disposition can be finkish, blocking manifestation of another

Example:

- Perceiver + yellow disc → sensation of yellow
- But perceiver's disposition disappears upon interaction

IV. Failed Resistance Strategies

Lewis considers attempts to rescue the SCA.

A. Timing Objection (p. 145–146)

- Maybe the disposition persists briefly after stimulus?
- Lewis replies:
    - Some dispositions require **processes over time**
    - If interrupted, manifestation fails

Finkishness survives.

B. Compound Disposition Strategy (p. 146–147)

- Claim: finkish cases involve **two dispositions**
  - One to produce r
  - One to remove that disposition

Lewis's reply:

- Introduces **extrinsic finks** (sorcerer case):
  - The loss of disposition is caused externally
  - Therefore, no "compound disposition" within the object

Undermines this strategy.

V. Key Metaphysical Commitment: Intrinsicality

Lewis relies on:

> **Dispositions are intrinsic properties** (p. 147–148)

- Intrinsic duplicates must share dispositions
- This blocks attempts to explain finkishness via external interference

VI. The Solution: A Reformed Conditional Analysis

Lewis rejects both:

- Simple conditional analysis
- Martin's radical dispositional essentialism

Instead, he proposes a **refined analysis grounded in causal bases**.

A. Causal Bases (p. 149)

- A disposition is grounded in a **causal basis (B)**:
  - A property that, together with stimulus s, causes response r

Key idea:

- Dispositions are tied to **underlying causal structure**

B. Structure of the Analysis

Analysandum (unchanged):

x is disposed at t to give r to s

Analysans (final version, p. 156–157):

- There exists an **intrinsic property B** such that:
  - If x were subjected to s
  - And retained B long enough
  - Then:
    - s + B would jointly be an **x-complete cause** of r

Important Technical Features

1. Counterfactual with Retention Clause

- We evaluate:
  - *If x were subjected to s AND retained B…*

This blocks finkish interference.

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2. Intrinsic Property Requirement

- B must be intrinsic
- Avoids extrinsic finks (e.g., sorcerer)

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3. x-Complete Cause (p. 156)

- Cause must include **all relevant intrinsic properties**
- Prevents partial or accidental causal contributions

VII. Subtleties and Implications

1. Variable Strictness of Counterfactuals (p. 150)

- Two counterfactuals can both be true:
  - If p → not q
  - If p & q → r

This explains how:

- Dispositions can have causal bases
- Even when they wouldn't manifest if tested

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2. Multiple Realizability of Dispositions (p. 149–150)

- Different objects can have:
  - Different causal bases
  - Same disposition

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3. Opposite Dispositions (p. 157)

- A single object can be:
  - Disposed to break
  - Disposed not to break

If one disposition is finkish.

VIII. Rejected Alternative: "Ceteris Paribus" Fix

Proposal:

- "x is fragile iff it would break if struck, *ceteris paribus*"

Lewis's objection (p. 157–158):

- If we hold intrinsic properties fixed:
    - The object cannot deform → no breaking

Over-correction: explains away the phenomenon.

IX. Big Picture

The Problem

- Dispositions cannot be reduced to simple counterfactuals because:
    - **Finkish cases break the connection between disposition and manifestation**

Lewis's Solution

- Retain a **conditional analysis**, but:
    - Anchor it in **causal bases**
    - Add **retention conditions**
    - Require **intrinsic properties**
    - Use **x-complete causation**

X. Conceptual Takeaways

- Dispositions are:
    - **Not identical to counterfactuals**
    - But still analyzable using **counterfactual structure + causation**
- The debate reveals tension between:
    - **Humean reductionism** (Lewis's inclination)
    - **Dispositional essentialism** (Martin)
